

Keywords Tab - How to Write a Search

A quick reference for adding news searches. One row = one topic.

The two columns you need

- **query** - what to search for. Everything in this guide is about this column.
- **active** - type **Y** to run it, **N** to pause it.

All other columns are optional. Leave them blank and sensible defaults are used.

Writing the query

1. Basic search

He types	What Google finds
gas tax California	Articles containing all three words, anywhere in the text
Gas, Tax, California	Same as above - commas are removed automatically
GAS TAX CALIFORNIA	Same as above - capital letters do not matter

Why: Good default for most topics.

2. Exact phrase - use quotes

He types	What Google finds
"gas tax" California	The words gas tax side by side, plus California
"Thousand Oaks" wildfire	The city name as one unit, plus wildfire
"Deborah Klein Lopez"	Only her full name - not any Lopez

Why: Without quotes, gas tax matches an article that says gas in one paragraph and tax in another. Quotes force the words together. Use quotes for any name, place or phrase that means something as a whole.

3. Either one - use OR

He types	What Google finds
"gas tax" OR "fuel tax" California	Either phrase, plus California
wildfire OR "brush fire" Malibu	Either word, plus Malibu

Why: Reporters describe the same thing in different ways. OR catches both.

Important: OR must be in capitals. Lowercase or is searched as an ordinary word.

4. Exclude a word - use a minus sign

He types	What Google finds
wildfire California -Australia	California wildfire news, nothing about Australia

He types	What Google finds
"Simi Valley" -football -basketball	Simi Valley news, without sports
insurance California -car -auto	Home insurance, not car insurance

Why: Removes a known source of unwanted results.

Important: no space between the minus and the word. Write -car, not - car.

5. Headline only - use intitle:

He types	What Google finds
intitle:"FAIR Plan"	Articles with FAIR Plan in the headline
intitle:Nordblum	Articles where Ted is named in the headline

Why: Much stricter. If a phrase is in the headline, the article is about it rather than mentioning it in passing. Use this when a topic keeps returning loosely related stories.

6. One website only - use site:

He types	What Google finds
site:calmatters.org housing	Housing stories from CalMatters only
site:vcstar.com "Thousand Oaks"	Ventura County Star coverage of Thousand Oaks

Why: When you trust a particular outlet and want only its coverage.

7. How far back - use when:

He types	What Google finds
"gas tax" California	Last 24 hours - added automatically
"gas tax" California when:3d	Last 3 days
"Klein Lopez" when:7d	Last 7 days
"FAIR Plan" when:12h	Last 12 hours

Why: Quiet topics may have no news in 24 hours. Widen the window for slow issues. If nothing is written, 24 hours is used.

8. Combining them

Everything above can be mixed in a single row:

Example
"gas tax" OR "fuel tax" California -Texas when:3d
intitle:"FAIR Plan" California -auto
"Thousand Oaks" OR "Simi Valley" wildfire -Australia

9. Special feeds - prefixes

He types	What it does
GEO:Thousand Oaks	All local news Google has for that place, with no topic filter
RSS:https://calmatters.org/feed/	Everything a specific outlet publishes
X:"FAIR Plan" California	Searches X instead of news (requires the X setup)

Mistakes to avoid

Do not write	Why	Write instead
tax	Every tax story in America	"property tax" California
state budget spending	No place - returns other states	"state budget" California
I want news about rising rents	Searches for I, want, about...	"rent increase" California
(gas OR fuel) tax	Google ignores brackets	"gas tax" OR "fuel tax"
gas tax or fuel tax	Lowercase or is a word	"gas tax" OR "fuel tax"
Three topics in one row	It becomes one search, not three	One topic per row

Two golden rules: put a place in every query, and put quotes around anything that belongs together.

The optional columns

Column	What it does	If left blank
terms	Words that must appear in the article, or it is discarded. Separate with or commas: gas tax fuel tax	No filter
places	Places that must appear in the article. Same format: Thousand Oaks Simi Valley	No filter
priority	1 to 5. Higher numbers rank above other stories.	4
scope	district, state or national. district gives a ranking boost.	state
type	issue, name, geo or feed. Use name for people - ranks higher.	issue
topic_label	A short name for the topic, shown in the results.	The query text

Tip: only use terms and places when a search keeps returning junk. For most rows, a well-written query with quotes and a place is enough.